FREE CHECKLIST FOR CHARITIES AND COMMUNITY GROUPS

Funder and trustee reporting checklist

Twelve checks before your figures leave the building. Tick the ones that are true for your next report.

Before you start

- [ ] **1. One purpose, one deadline.** You know which report this is, who reads it, what decision it supports, the period it covers and when it's due.
- [ ] **2. One owner.** A named person assembles it, and you know who supplies each part, who checks it, who signs it off, and who covers if they're away.
- [ ] **3. A list of sources.** Each spreadsheet or system the figures come from is written down, with who keeps it and the cut-off date.

Counting the same way every time

- [ ] **4. Definitions written down.** What counts as a participant, a session, an attendance and an outcome is written in one place.
- [ ] **5. People and attendances kept apart.** You report unique people separately from total attendances, and say which one each funder asked for.
- [ ] **6. The same definitions for every funder.** Where a funder needs something different, you work it out from the same records and note the difference.

Checking before sign-off

- [ ] **7. Totals add back.** Every headline figure can be traced back to the activity records it came from.
- [ ] **8. Compared with last time.** Big changes since the last report are explained, not quietly adjusted.
- [ ] **9. Duplicates and gaps checked.** You've looked for people counted twice, missing months or sites, and late returns.
- [ ] **10. Problems listed, not hidden.** Anything missing, doubtful or estimated is on a short list that the person signing off can see.

Making next time easier

- [ ] **11. A short how-to.** The steps, file locations and deadlines are written down so someone else could produce the report.
- [ ] **12. Evidence kept for bids.** Volunteer hours, feedback and outcomes are recorded in a way you could use in your next application.

How did you score?

10–12: a solid process. Your figures will stand up to questions.

6–9: workable, but it relies on people remembering things. Start with the gaps in the first two sections.

0–5: fragile. One absence or a new funder could cause real problems. Fix definitions and ownership first.

Three questions for your next team meeting

1. Which step causes the most last-minute chasing or copying?
2. Which figure would be hardest for someone else to reproduce next month?
3. What should trustees see as a known issue rather than discover as a surprise?

This checklist is a practical guide, not accounting, audit or legal advice. You don't need to share any personal data to use it. If you'd like help, the £345 Reporting & Insight Review looks at one of your reports in detail: zktheory.org/services.